

Notes on the Poetic Image of the *Patria*

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In a larger measure than perhaps any of the other countries of major cultural caliber, Italy for many centuries could be regarded as an invention of its poets. From at least the time when Dante was writing the divine poem to the time when Leopardi was a young man, the country which did not exist as a unified political entity was a congruous reality and an important image through the work of its poets. Indeed, literature did not create only an image of Italy but concomitantly also that of the poets themselves as her natural interpreters and judges. We have the most memorable instances in mind when we say that the attitude of those great Italians toward Italy, whose image they so potently contributed to form, is quite complex and critical. They were giving the country her literary speech and in the highest examples they did not use it in an exclamatory and celebrative vein; on the contrary, the typical attitude is one of manly compassion and sorrowful censure.

The standard sequence to describe this line is Dante-Petrarch-Machiavelli. One of the running themes in Italy's national poem is that of national corruption and lack of leadership; the time-honored metaphor of the ship of state is used by Dante; and the ship, as everyone remembers, is a pilotless one in a stormy sea. As frequently in classical tragedy, the *polis* is corrupt, its rulers are inadequate, the temporal center does not hold. Italy, of course, is feminine; ideally the noblest of women (*donna*, *domina*), she is "now" lacerated through the behavior of inept and quarrelsome children — a state

of affairs which Dante was certainly neither the first nor the last to visualize, though he did so, as usual, in the most definitive and memorable diction: *non donna di provincie, ma bordello*. Somewhat more diffusely and sensuously, Petrarch resumed the image of the *patria* as the lacerated lady in the splendidly eloquent and sorrowful opening of *Italia mia*; later in the poem, the native earth is identified with the image of the benign and pious mother ("Non è questo 'l terren ch' i' toccai pria?... Non è questa la patria in ch'io mi fido, / Madre benigna e pia / Che copre l'un e l'altro mio parente?")¹ In the same poem the theme of Italy-Romanism vs. Teutonism-Barbarity, a theme in many ways fraught with rhetorical danger, also makes its solemn appearance. It will be imitated, and involuntarily caricatured, in patriotic versifying and in political oratory for centuries. The noblest and most magniloquent resumption of that theme is, of course, in the close of Machiavelli's *Prince* ending with the Petrarch quotation about *virtù* and *furore*. The Machiavelli passage is also significant because it comes at the close of a political treatise famed for the practicality of its assumptions and views; the cultural dream of the *patria* finds one of its major expressions in Machiavelli, who, incidentally, considered himself a poet.

Several centuries later, a conclusive expression, along this poetic line, by a major poet, is the dyptich of *canzoni* composed by Leopardi when he was twenty years old (1818), *All'Italia* and *Sopra il monumento di Dante*. Especially *All'Italia* with its classic opening, "O patria mia," etc., can be described as an exercise in patriotic poetry in the grand manner; the poet, the Nation's *vates*, is officiating, performing a literary rite; reference to the Petrarchan tradition is not only natural, it is part of the *genre's* requirements; the poem is a ceremony, with its proper formulas. It must be observed, however, that young Leopardi's poetic and civic vitality did emerge nevertheless, making him, at this early stage at least, a true Risorgi-